Weekly podcast: design and build plan

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The chat room window on the Web page becomes a weekly video podcast: two original hosts talk through the week in wrestling, written from what really happened in your game, with paper-doll animation and closed captions on every line.

What the chat room is today

The chat room is one window on the Web page, and only the window goes. The posts behind it stay, because other screens read them.

- **The window:** `app/src/screens/net/Feed.tsx`, shown by `Web.tsx` as the "Chat room" window between the dirt sheet and Wrestle Search. It is read only: "You are lurking."
- **The posts:** `S.feed`, written in `src/94-net.js` after every show (winners, losers, new champions, the company, the columnist) and two to four fan lines from the `GR_CHAT` grammar in `src/60-grammar.js`.
- **Who else reads `S.feed`:** the desk shows a wrestler's post (`office/Desk.tsx`). The broadcast's Ringside feed is a separate list and is not touched.
- **Tests that name it:** `app/tests/net.js` (the window, the scroll, the empty room) and `test-grammar.js` (chat lines).

So the plan keeps `S.feed` and `GR_CHAT` as raw material. Fan lines become listener mail and wrestlers' posts become quotes the hosts react to. Nothing in the save is thrown away.

The show and its two hosts

The show follows the shape of a weekly newsletter radio show: a writer who knows everything and a former wrestler who keeps him honest. Both hosts are original game characters with no real person's name, voice or look (rule 3).

	The writer (host A)	The ex-wrestler (host B)
Who they are in the game	The press reporter on the ring beat, already in `S.press` with a name, a lean and how warm they are to you	A retired wrestler from the world with a good mic (a second career). If there is none, an original name from the press name lists
How they talk	Long, sure of the facts, history callbacks, star ratings for everything	Short, dry jokes, says how a match was worked, argues the other side
What they know	What the press knows: sure, likely and thin rumours, and corrections when wrong	What the locker room thinks: morale, who is hot, who looked lost
Running bits	Rates the catering in stars. "We have a lot to get to."	Times the writer's tangents. Asks "was it a good match though?"

The show takes its name from the world's dirt sheet: `S.columnist` plus "Radio" ("The Ringside Wire Radio" by default). A world package can bring its own show name and hosts later.

Because host A is a press reporter, the court and freeze actions you already have carry over. Take them to dinner and the takes on your shows warm up; freeze them out and the podcast turns on you.

An episode, segment by segment

One episode comes out at the end of every week, about 40 to 70 lines and three to six minutes at normal speed. Each segment runs only when the week gave it something true to say (the grammar's rule), so no two weeks sound the same.

#	Segment	What they talk about	Where it comes from
1	Cold open	Theme sting, title card, one line on the biggest story of the week	The top entry in this week's causal log (`S.clog`)

#	Segment	What they talk about	Where it comes from
2	Your show	Grade against the crowd, best match in stars, the finish, a title change, a turn	The show report from `SHOWX`: `segs`, `rating`, `exp`, `att`, `sellout`, `change`
3	The other shows	Rivals' big nights, who stole a show	Rival show reports and their `big` flag
4	Feud watch	Which feud is hot, which is dragging, which just ended	`S.feuds`: `heat`, `fresh`, `res`, `end`
5	Business	Crowds, gates, audience share, network trouble, contracts	`E.shareOf`, `S.news` (contract, world), the networks
6	Rumour mill	"I am hearing...", host B doubts it; last week's calls checked	`netRumours()` levels and `S.rumR` confirmations and corrections
7	The title picture	Every champion, who is next in line, a top ten	Titles and holders, `E.rankFor`
8	Mailbag	Listener mail read out	The `GR_CHAT` fan lines, now written as mail with a screen name
9	Picks and sign off	Picks for the next big night, then goodbye	`nextBigName()` and the hot feuds; picks are kept and scored next episode

Every four weeks the episode adds the month in review from `S.pm`, and once a year a season special. Wrestlers' own posts from `S.feed` are quoted inside segments 2 and 3 ("After the show, X posted...").

Animation, voices and closed captions

The podcast is a video podcast drawn by the diorama engine the game already has, so it needs no new kind of art. Most pieces exist today: the desk scene with mouths that move (`deskScene` in `app/src/kit/scene.ts`), suited and headset dolls, keyframes, camera moves and captions in four styles.

The picture

- A new set, **the studio**: two microphones on arms, headphones, a desk with the newsletter and a coffee, an ON AIR light, the show's name lettered on card behind them. It is cut from card like every other set (rule 2a).
- Two host dolls with their own looks (glasses and a cardigan for A, a cap and a t-shirt for B), built from the same recipes as wrestlers.
- Loops per line: A talking, B talking, both laughing, an argument, reading mail off a sheet.
- **Cutaways** while they talk about something: the champion with the belt over the shoulder (dolls already wear belts), the two in a feud face to face, the poster for the next show, a top ten board with portraits, a star card for the best match. These are the same pictures Bill asked for elsewhere, so the work is shared.

The voices

- Default: a short babble of soft tones per syllable, pitched per host, from the sound code already in `app/src/sfx.ts`. It works on every computer with no files, like the voices in many handmade games.
- Option: the computer's own text to speech where it has voices. Some computers have no voices installed, so it is never required.

Closed captions

- On by default, at the bottom of the picture, each line with the speaker's name in their colour. Sound tags in brackets: [theme plays], [laughs], [papers rustle].
- Options for caption size and a solid box behind them.
- A **transcript** tab beside the player lists every line, so an episode can be read instead of watched. Segments are chapters you can jump to.
- A line stays up for its length in words at the reading speed set in Options. Reduce motion shows still pictures and the captions still advance.

How it keeps the game's rules

The podcast only reads the game, the same way the Net section does today.

- **Never changes a game:** every pick uses `h01()` hashes, never `rnd(S)`, so `test-determinism.js` still passes and a podcast line can never change a result.
- **Fog of war:** the hosts know what the press knows. A secret that has not leaked is never said on air, and thin rumours are sometimes wrong and corrected later.
- **Saves:** episodes live in a new `S.pod` (the last four, like the dirt sheet's four issues). It is made the first time it is needed, so old saves load with no version bump (rule 9).

- **Engine owns the game:** the engine writes the script; the screen only plays it (rule 1).
- **No outside files:** set, dolls, babble and theme sting are all drawn or played by code (rule 2).
- **Four inputs:** play, pause, next and last line, chapters and captions are real buttons with `data-t` names, so mouse, touch, keys and a pad all work (rule 5).
- **Plain words, no dice wording, stars after the bell:** the new lines go through `test-wording.js` and `test-grammar.js` (rules 4, 8, 8a).
- **Information only:** Web stays a page with nothing to decide (rule 6). The player opens as a pop-up from a short tile (rule 6a).

Screen size (Bill, 21 October): built for 1080p only, using the whole screen. The player opens full screen: the picture large on the left, the chapters and transcript in a column on the right, and the controls along the bottom. There is no Steam Deck or small-screen layout.

Build plan

Four phases, each one a pull request that leaves the game working. Phases 1 and 2 give a playable podcast on the existing desk set; phase 3 makes it look finished.

1. **The script (engine).** About two days.
   - New `src/99-zpodcast.js`, named to sort after `99-press.js` and `99-postmortem.js` so its end-of-week hook runs after theirs. It writes `S.pod.eps[0]` = `{w, n, title, segs, lines}`; each line is `{who, t, seg, pic}`, where `pic` says which loop or cutaway to show.
   - New rule set `GR_POD` in `src/60-grammar.js`, with each host's voice. `GR_CHAT` stays and feeds the mailbag.
   - `E.podcast(S)` and `E.podEp(S, n)` for the screen. The hosts are picked once and kept in `S.pod.hosts`.
   - New `test-podcast.js`: 60 weeks of every company, an episode each week, every segment true of the game, no empty slots, no secret said early, same seed gives the same words. Add it to CLAUDE.md's command list.
2. **The player (screen).** About two days.
   - `app/src/screens/net/Podcast.tsx` replaces `Feed.tsx` in the Web page's middle window: the newest episode as a tile, the last four below it.

- The pop-up player: `ScenePlayer` in a 16 by 9 box on the desk set for now, captions, transcript, chapters, the babble voice, and play, pause, next, last and speed controls.
- A note on the notification bar when a new episode is up and your show is in it.
- Update `app/tests/net.js` from chat room checks to podcast checks; update the start screen line, README and CLAUDE.md rule 6.

3. **The studio and the cutaways (look).** About three days.
   - The studio set and the two host dolls in `scene.ts` and `puppet.ts`, made in Create a Scene like the game's other scenes.
   - Cutaways: champion with the belt on the shoulder, face to face, poster, top ten board, star card.
   - The theme sting and caption options.
4. **Depth (later, pick and choose).**
   - Picks scored over the year ("the writer is 31 and 12 this year").
   - Book a wrestler as a guest from Manage: a good mic lifts them, a bad one is a story.
   - A world package brings its own show name and hosts; a rival company's podcast.
   - Call-in callers with their own voices; the computer's speech as an option.

Calls for Bill

- [ ] **Go ahead to build?** The plan is phases 1 and 2 on a branch, then a pull request for you to try. Nothing is changed in the repo yet.
- [ ] **Information only, or a small effect?** Recommended: information only, like the rest of Web. The alternative is that the hosts' take nudges how fans feel about a wrestler a little.
- [ ] **Voices:** babble plus captions by default, with the computer's speech as an option. Say if you want speech on by default.
- [ ] **The show name:** "The Ringside Wire Radio" from the dirt sheet, or a name you pick.